PTI



MAGIC LAMP?
The LJP (RV) chief makes a splash at a Patna event in April

CHIRAG'S TRICK SHOTS

The Paswan factor is in play again. Seeking a prince's share of seats, angling for CM's chair, the LJP heir's moves spook JD(U)

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

Takeaways

- **Chirag aims to be back in the reckoning; LJP wants eight tickets each for its 5 LS seats. Nitish camp sees red**
- **Chirag had played spoiler for JD(U) in 2020, whittling down its seat tally to 43**

CHIRAG PASWAN IS quite the lamp that burns bright. A 5/5 tally in 2024, a berth in the Union cabinet, and Bihar's 5.31 per cent Paswan electorate safe in his black designer suit pocket.... And yet, when the 42-year-old chief of the Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) turned heads in April, it was with a poetic invocation: "*Bihar mujhe bula raha hai.*" You couldn't miss the rhyme. He was getting 'the call of Bihar' just in time for assembly polls, due by November. The keyword is ambition. "Do you think he'll come to Patna merely to serve as a minister? No, the only office that interests him is the CM's chair," says an aide.

The ruling JD(U)'s corps commanders are irked. Is it a solo quest for Bihar's top job? A ploy to secure more seats? Or, alarmingly, a chess move by the BJP to reshape alliance dynamics? The spectre of 2020 looms large. Then, Chirag had exited the NDA but only to do man-to-man marking on CM Nitish Kumar's party. As a classic spoiler, his party won only one seat but sliced off 2.38 million votes across 135 others. Catastrophically for the JD(U), the runoff tilted the scales in 38 seats. Its tally collapsed from 115 to 43, the BJP surged to 74: the imbalance had spurred Nitish's last breakup.

Now, Chirag is in play again as a confounding variable. Landing on the scene with all his éclat, he has put up a stiff bargain: eight tickets for every LS seat he won, or 40-odd. His party argues that it is fair. But in NDA seat splits, the JD(U) has never settled for less than 115 of Bihar's 243 seats. It has reasons to be spooked by the BJP's strategic ambiguity, for Nitish has not even been declared the CM face. Watch this space. ■

A BAN

As a simple community game



By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

GIVEN A GAME OF CHANCE, CHANCES are it can always gather big stakes—all it needs is for the society around it to change. That's what happened to Housie, the cherished pastime that Goa banned in April. Once a harmless form of community entertainment, Housie—also called tambola or bingo—helped fund sports, cultural events and local festivals. But somewhere along the line, it got kissed by the gods of lucre, and metamorphosed into a multicrore business.

"Tickets are now priced at Rs 1,000 and some 9,000 tickets are sold per event," says a state official. A high-profile event in Margao recently had a total prize money of Rs 13 lakh; another promised Rs